INTRODUCTION

The years 2020 and 2021 have been traumatic for the world as it battled a raging global pandemic brought upon by the novel coronavirus, called the severe acute respiratory syndrome coronavirus (SARS-CoV-2), which causes the disease we now identify as COVID-19. It has been even more agonizing for the bereaved families who lost their loved ones, the brave frontline warriors, healthcare professionals and countries whose health systems collapsed under the sheer numbers and speed at which their citizens were impacted by the unrelenting virus. India, home to 18 per cent of the world's population, had to cope with three particularly strong waves of the virus: the first, from April to November 2020, the second, more ferocious one, between March and June 2021 and the third, which started in January 2022. When the first wave hit us, we braced ourselves having witnessed the devastation already caused by the virus in other countries, despite superior healthcare infrastructure. Doomsday predictions of starvation and mass deaths took over the global media with the inherent assumption that if western nations were unable to rein in the virus, then India, with its weak socio-economic and healthcare infrastructure, didn't even stand a fighting chance.

As the pandemic progressed, Indians united and fought the virus with great tenacity in the face of profound adversity. With timely lockdowns, disciplined mask usage, quick medical infrastructure upgrades, widespread adaptation of digital technologies, science-based regulations and vaccine adoption, we emerged with much lesser damage than many large, developed nations of the world. Hovering at an average of 1.11 per cent through the pandemic, India's fatality has been the lowest in the world, leaving sceptics astounded. Despite totally shutting down our economy for a limited period of time during the initial days of the pandemic, India has managed to get it back on track with sound, strategic regulatory responses. We have also been the quickest country to administer over 1.6 billion vaccine doses in a matter